mission, which is mandated to redraw constituency boundaries and determine scheduled caste/ tribe reserved seats based on demographic distribution.

Since Independence, India has conducted four major delimitation exercises. The first three—in 1952, 1963, and 1973—followed the censuses of 1951, 1961 and 1971, respectively. Each exercise adjusted the number of seats in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies in line with the population growth. The number of LS seats rose incrementally—from 494 to 522, and finally 543 after 1971. The exercise also adjusted constituency boundaries to ensure equal representation per voter across states.

However, in 1976, the Indira Gandhi-led government imposed a freeze on the reallocation of seats through the 42nd Constitutional Amendment. The primary rationale was to encourage population control measures—there was a growing concern that states with higher population growth (mainly in the North) would gain more seats at the cost of those that had successfully controlled their population (mainly in the South). To prevent this perceived imbalance, it was decided that the seat distribution would remain based on the 1971 Census. This freeze was originally meant to last until 2001, but it was extended to 2026 through the 84th Constitutional Amendment in 2002.

The 2002 delimitation exercise thus was limited to redrawing constituency boundaries in states based on the 2001 Census data, and also revising the reservation of seats for SC/ STs to reflect their population distribution in each state.

Now, as the freeze on seat reallocation nears its 2026 deadline, India faces the challenge of conducting a full-fledged delimitation exercise. The next Census—originally scheduled for 2021 but delayed due to the Covid pandemic—is expected to be the basis for this exercise.

Why the South is worried

With the new Parliament building designed to accommodate 888 MPs, a significant increase in seats is a strong possibility, ensuring that no state loses representation outright. Constitutional expert P.D.T. Achary explains that while



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BIG PUSH Shah with BJP state chief Annamalai and others, Coimbatore, Feb. 26

"Mr Stalin, the Modi government has made it clear that after delimitation, on pro rata basis, not a single seat will be reduced in any southern state"

AMIT SHAH, *Union Minister of Home*

Article 82 mandates the reallocation of Lok Sabha seats after each Census to reflect demographic shifts, Article 81 imposes a cap of 550 seats—530 for states and 20 for Union territories. Consequently, any expansion of the total number of seats would require an amendment to Article 81.

The impending delimitation exercise could significantly alter the political representation of India's northern and southern states. If the number of Lok Sabha seats remains 543, northern states—particularly Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, MP, and Rajasthan—stand to gain 31 seats, while southern states—especially Tamil Nadu, Kerala, and Andhra Pradesh—will lose 26 seats (see *Biggest Gainers/ Biggest Losers*). This shift is due to the North's higher population growth and persistently high fertility rates and could lead to an imbalance in policy priorities.

However, if the total number of Lok Sabha seats is increased to 848—as calculated in a 2019 study—the changes become even starker. The four northern states would gain 150 seats while the five in the south would see a net gain of only 35 seats. The disproportionate advantage given to the North would further reduce the South's influence in national decision-making. This imbalance is particularly concerning because, while the North accounts for only 24 per cent of India's GDP, the South contributes 31 per cent. A shift in representation without proportional consideration of economic contributions could increase tensions in fiscal federalism.

Southern states already feel underrepresented in national financial allocations and argue that representation should account for more than just